Syra Mashek

Reading Response #3

HIST/WMNS 402

Word Count:1,367

The essay *Slave Marriage and Family Relations* by Brenda E. Stevenson explained the complexity of marriage, relationships, sexuality, and family during slavery. Their experience of sexuality and family was different than the white experience. While the white slave masters had control over whom they marry and have relations with there was resistance to the slave masters "Slaves nonetheless had their own way of doing things, refusing to concede too much, sometimes refusing to concede at all."[1] While there were differences in relationships between slaves and masters, both of their "attitudes and decisions about marriage were shaped by gender convention and community concerns"[2] but these concerns were not the same. Stevenson stresses this agency that slaves had at the time over their own interpersonal lives and discusses the different ways agency was used through these social relations.

Many slave families, communities, and households performed in a matrifocal manner, contrasting the patrifocal and nuclear systems in place in many white households. Many slave holdings had a higher percentage of women than men, "giving slave women great influence in their families and communities."[3] This power and influence these women had been driven by knowledge, wisdom, and history. This would put them in a position of authority over other slaves, and often many would seek advice, counsel, and permission for things such as marriage. For example, Caroline Johnson Harris, when describing her marriage and courtship said that "Aunt Sue" gave permission for them to wed, but did not look for confirmation from their master. For the couple to be married, they approached Aunt Sue for her blessing and were instructed to take a few days to think about it. After thinking about it the couple returned with the decision to wed, and Aunt Sue granted them permission.[4] Another example was a mother denying her child the ability the marry the person she chose. These examples show the power

[1] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 159.
[2] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 159.
[3] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 160.
[4] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 160.

women held within the community. Slave women were socialized by the women of their community and were supposed to "take pride in their "womanly" skills and service they rendered their families."[5] Because the women held the head role of the family in the matriarchal system it was their job to protect their dependent, even if it means rebelling against the salve owner. Most women were unable to openly rebel against their owner, but those who did were appreciated and held at the upmost respect, with their stories being told in a heroic sense to the next generations. Many of these stories were told to daughters as a part of socialization.[6]

While women within the community held power over decisions, the slave master would hold the upmost power and decision making. When approaching the master with the want to wed, the master may ask questions about their feelings for each other and deny or allow the marriage and "If the couple had the same master, there usually was no problem gaining his or her permission."[7] Overall, slaveholders did not agree to marriages unless it gave them an advantage such as the ability to manipulate the slave by using the family as leverage, and procreation.[8] In other situations, a couple may be owned by different masters, and the husbands were offered visitation to see the wife by the masters. Both men and women in these abroad marriages saw advantages for example, the women had more domestic power and allow them to raise children as they see fit. Men had leisurely and reasons to do with manhood which made the abroad marriage appealing. For example, both black and white men viewed "travel as an "adventure" [and] as a "natural" desire and activity of a "man"."[9] The author also pointed out that this then extends the men's social world and allowed them a 'break' "from their daily physical and psychological routines."[10] Another reason men would marry abroad is due to what they view as manhood which is "his ability to protect his wife and children."[11] When in proximity of his wife and children he would likely often witness the ongoing abuse they have inflicted upon them, and when marrying abroad they have a chance to protect their inability to protect their family against the slave masters.

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[5] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 165.
[6] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 165.
[7] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 160.
[8] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 171.
[9] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 162.
[10] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 162.
[11] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 162.

While women were the head of the households it was still part of their 'duty' to be subservient to sexual desires, "A woman's submission to her man went hand in hand with her service to her family and community."[12] Not only were women having to submit to black men, they were also supposed to submit to white men "men of either race might have used whatever advantage they had to seduce or even to exploit and sometimes abuse these women."[13]

Black women were often sexually abused and coerced by white men, and their masters this resulting in what the author defines as mulatto children. Miscegenation was "frequent, but not spoken about openly"[14] and slaves were threatened with whippings and being sold if anyone were to find out. The author describes miscegenation as "as sterile, emotionless term that often shrouds acts of sexual submission characterized by violence and degradation."[15] Not only did miscegenation victimize black women and biracial children it also emasculated black men, as black men often found themselves in the position of competing with the slave holders for the same woman. When slave husbands and men did intervene when women were raped it resulted in retaliatory actions. Many slave women were also coerced into having intercourse with the slave holder by being granted emancipation, clothes, food, and better housing.

Another aspect of relationships at this time between slaves is polygamy. Polygamy described by the author is where"[16] a slave man had a longstanding, contiguous intimate relationships with more than one woman. The author claims this could be due to the larger number of women within the slave holdings, and the internal and external pressures for women to "breed". Many of these accounts are not available due to emancipation because "polygynous marriages could not be legalized after general emancipation"[17] which led to the camouflaging or change to this part of their lives. Due to the spread of monogamy by churches and law, any other style of relationship can be viewed as promiscuous or immoral.

The main theme I thought was interesting from this reading was that even in a matrifocal household, women are still actively being oppressed and abused by all men, and there are social expectations for women to provide children and become a wife, "usually by the time slave girls

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[12] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 167.
[13] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 167.
[14] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 168.
[15] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 168.
[16] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 164.
[17] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 164.

reached their teens, these women already had prepared them to take on the most important commitment of their adult lives- motherhood and marriage."[18] Even while they hold the title of the head of the household, they must make decisions considering whether or not their abroad husband would agree, "A woman's role as head of a matrifocal family mandated that she male some of her family's most vital decisions and suffer the consequences if her master or her abroad husband disagrees."[19]

[18] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 165.
[19] Stevenson, "Slave Marriage and Family Relations" (1996), in *MPHAS*, page 164.

Bibliography

Brenda E. Stevenson, “Slave Marriage and Family Relations”, (1996), in *Major Problems in the History of American Sexuality*. Edited by Kathy Peiss. New York: Houghton Mifflin Company, 2002. Pages 159-173.